

General NIH R grant Suggested Specific Aims Outline

Specific Aims (1 page limit)

Paragraph 1: Introductory

Opening Sentence: Open with one sentence that immediately introduces the reviewer to the general topic your proposal addresses. Be sure that it is not overly general – it should provide some information that is not common knowledge.

Current Knowledge: Follow the opening sentence with 3-4 sentences that summarize what is known in the field. This should also set up the gap in knowledge that your research will address.

Critical Problem, Need or Gap in Knowledge: Specifically state the gap in knowledge that your research will address. What needs to be determined to move the field forward?

Gap as an important problem: End the first paragraph by stating why the gap in knowledge is a problem. What vertical leap in the field does it prevent?

Paragraph 2: What? Why? Who?

Long-term Goal: State the long-term goal (10 years) of your research. Your long-term goal should clearly encompass the research that you are proposing.

Objective of this Proposal: State the objective of *this* application. The objective should directly address the knowledge gap or need stated in paragraph 1.

Central Hypothesis: State your central hypothesis simply and clearly. *Italicize this sentence.*

Rationale for Hypothesis: 1-2 sentences describing how hypothesis was formulated (mention preliminary data if applicable).

Closing the Gap: What will the results of your proposed work make possible that is not possible now? This should refer back to the last sentence of paragraph 1 (Why is the gap in knowledge a problem/ what vertical leap does it prevent?)

Qualifications: It is a good idea to state why you (or your team or collaborators) are particularly well-prepared to carry out this work. This works well here or in the opening of the final (“payoff”) paragraph.

Paragraph 3: Specific Aims statements

State each aim clearly and simply. Follow each Aim statement with ~3 sentences stating your working hypothesis for that aim, what that hypothesis is based on, and a brief summary of your approach. Make sure the Aims are conceptual rather than procedural (i.e., they focus on the desired knowledge or outcome, not the process).

Specific Aim 1: Determine.....

Working hypothesis:

Approach:

Paragraph 4: Payoff paragraph

Innovation: “The proposed work is innovative because.....”

Expected Outcomes: Summarize the expected outcomes of the work. There should be at least one outcome per Aim. Use a strong verb here: “We expect that....” (not hope or believe or think.)

Impact: End with a general statement about the positive impact of your work. This should address the funding agency’s mission and, if applicable, the purpose of the specific request for proposals.